

Is it Ethical to Use ChatGPT Despite Its Energy Consumption?

Posted by u/PhilippinePatriot • • 0 points • 49 comments

I've been using ChatGPT for a while now and one thing I've struggled with is the energy requirements for AI. I understand that using an AI system requires more energy than regular search functions and its something always felt guilty about given how much energy it uses, especially since it leads to increased reliance on dangerous energy sources like coal. Just want to hear other peoples thoughts.

Comments

u/Spacing-Guild-Mentat • 1 points • 2025-10-26 10:36 UTC

The most unethical thing about ChatGPT is not the energy consumption but the spread of stupidity by making people actually dumber with every single use of it.

u/Legitimate-Maybe-326 • 1 points • 2025-07-30 13:46 UTC

This is misinformation. The actual fact is:

According to a Sustainability by numbers article, a single ChatGPT query consumes roughly 3 watt-hours.

A standard Google search typically uses around 0.3 watt-hours.

Even Sam Altman says that saying “thank you” to chat, burns millions of dollars. As far as clean water usage, the book Empire of AI describes the quantity of clean water that Open AI and others are using in the AI arms race. Read it. It will open your eyes.

Understand that many people are addicted to using Char GPT and therefore don't want to hear this. (Thus the above post authoritatively giving the impression that chat requests take little to no energy comparatively is celebrated and quickly taken as gospel—but it just isn't true.